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The Making of a Wave

Rahul Gandhi entered what was potentially the most decisive year of his political life by being absent from the country. The young leader's foreign trips were the subject of much speculation within the media and even the Congress party. The bazaar gossip was that he was either in Dubai or London. 'He always spends New Year somewhere out, even Rajivji used to do it,' is how a Congressperson put it to me, rather defensively.

The Delhi that Rahul returned to in the first week of January 2014 was in the grip of a cold wave. What was also slowly becoming apparent was that in this general election year, the Congress party could soon be left out in the cold. The party had just been swept out in the four state assembly elections in December. The CNNIBN January election tracker brought more bad news—the NDA was now crossing the 230-seat mark; more significantly, the BJP alone was winning around 210 seats. The UPA was way behind, with around 120 seats; the Congress on its own was just below the three-figure mark. Price rise was still hurting, with retail inflation hovering around the double-digit mark. It was the number one public concern, according to our poll. The voters were still very angry with the UPA. The poll even showed that a majority believed that the prime minister had allowed, or had been unable to rein in, high-level corruption.

The other noteworthy statistic from the poll survey was the leadership battle between Rahul and Modi. When asked a straight question on who should be prime minister, 52 per cent preferred Modi, just 16 per cent wanted Rahul. The gap widened when the question was posed in north and west India. The only state where Rahul was ahead was in Kerala. The situation from a Congress perspective was grim.